

What Good Looks Like: Interior Design Collaboration UX

Research synthesis for **StyleMyShack** — what the best platforms do when a designer presents room-by-room recommendations to a client, and what's worth borrowing.

The Landscape

The platforms that matter for your use case fall into three buckets:

1. **Full-service collaboration portals** — Houzz Pro, Mydoma Studio, Programa, DesignerLogic, Techstyles
2. **Online design services** — Havenly, Decorilla, Spacejoy
3. **Inspiration/mood tools** — Houzz Ideabooks, Pinterest, Morpholio Board, Milanote

Your app lives in a unique niche: it's a **single-project, single-client tool** where the designer fills in room-by-room recommendations and the homeowner reviews them. You don't need the full SaaS portal — but you can steal the best interaction patterns from each bucket.

The 7 Patterns That Define "Good"

1. Room-Organized Navigation with Status at a Glance

Every serious tool organizes by room first, everything else second. What the best ones add:

- **Visual status indicators** on each room card (not started / in progress / ready for review / approved)
- **Cover photo** as the dominant element on each card — not the room name
- **Completion percentage** or a simple progress bar so the client knows where things stand

Your app already does this with room cards + emojis + cover photos. The gap: there's no concept of "status" visible to the client. Even a simple badge like "New recommendations" would help.

2. Selections Board: The Core Collaboration Surface

This is the single most important pattern in the industry. Houzz Pro's Selections tool is the gold standard.

How it works:

- The designer creates a visual board of product/material selections organized by category (paint, flooring, lighting, furniture, etc.)
- Each item has a photo, description, price, and link
- The client can **approve or decline each item with one click** (green check / red X)
- The client can **leave a comment on any specific item**
- The designer gets notified of every action

What makes it great:

- Decisions are **granular** — the client reacts to individual items, not the whole room at once
- Feedback is **anchored** to a specific thing, not floating in a text box
- There's a clear **status trail** — you can see what's been approved, what's pending, what's declined

For StyleMyShack: Your recommendations panel currently has free-text fields (paint_notes, flooring, lighting, furniture, general_notes). The jump from "wall of text" to "individual selectable items with approve/decline" is the single highest-value UX upgrade you could make. Even a lightweight version — where each recommendation category shows a few cards the client can thumbs-up or comment on — would be a major step.

3. Visual-First Presentation (Photos > Text)

Across every platform, the pattern is consistent: **show, don't tell.**

- Decorilla sends photorealistic 3D renderings of your space with the recommended furniture placed in it
- Havenly delivers mood boards with the specific products overlaid on room photos
- Houzz Pro lets designers attach mood boards and 3D floor plans alongside selections

Even without 3D rendering capability, the principle applies:

- **Inspiration photos** alongside each recommendation ("here's what I'm going for with the lighting")

- **Product photos** with links, not just text descriptions
- **Color swatches** rendered visually, not described in words

For StyleMyShack: You already have a `swatches` JSONB field and photo tabs (actual / 3D / floor plan). The opportunity is to make the *recommendation content itself* more visual — a paint recommendation should show the swatch color inline, a furniture rec should show a product photo, etc.

4. Two Views: Designer Edit Mode vs. Client Read Mode

Every collaboration tool separates these clearly:

- **Designer view:** Editable fields, drag-to-reorder, internal notes, pricing details, status controls
- **Client view:** Clean, read-only, focused on what matters — photos, descriptions, approve/decline buttons

Houzz Pro has a “Preview and Share” button where the designer controls *exactly* what the client sees (show/hide pricing, show/hide internal notes, enable/disable approvals).

For StyleMyShack: You already have this concept (designer edits, client reads). The refinement is making the edit experience feel more like a workspace (quick edits, drag-and-drop, inline editing) and the read experience feel more like a presentation (clean layout, no edit chrome, clear hierarchy).

5. The Intake Questionnaire / Style Quiz

Both Havenly and Decorilla start every project with a style quiz or questionnaire. The client picks rooms they like, rates fabric swatches, identifies preferences. This does two things:

- Gives the designer a **starting point** instead of a blank canvas
- Makes the client feel **invested** in the process from day one

For StyleMyShack: Not directly applicable since you have a single client/designer pair working on a specific cabin. But the *spirit* of the pattern is relevant: before the designer starts filling in recommendations, is there a way for the homeowner to express preferences? A simple “I like / I don’t like” photo selection per room could be useful intake.

6. Ideabooks / Inspiration Collections

Houzz’s Ideabooks are essentially shared Pinterest boards between designer and client:

- Either party can save photos and add comments

- Organized by room or by topic (e.g., “Kitchen Backsplash Options”)
- Comments are attached to specific images
- Can be shared or kept private

The UX value: it creates a **shared visual vocabulary** before formal recommendations begin. The designer and client align on taste before specific products are proposed.

For StyleMyShack: Your photo gallery tabs already serve part of this function. A lightweight addition: let the designer attach “inspiration” photos (not photos *of* the room, but photos *for* the room — “here’s the vibe I’m going for”). This could be a fourth tab alongside actual/3D/floorPlan.

7. Comment Threading on Specific Elements

The worst collaboration pattern: a single giant comment box for a whole room. The best collaboration pattern: **comments anchored to specific items**.

- Houzz Pro: comments per selection item
- Programa: feedback channels per design element
- Techstyles: comments linked to specific products with notifications

This turns vague feedback (“I’m not sure about the living room”) into actionable feedback (“I like the sofa but the coffee table feels too modern for the space”).

For StyleMyShack: Even without full item-level granularity, you could enable comments per *category* (paint, flooring, lighting, furniture) rather than one `general_notes` field for the whole room.

Common Pitfalls the Research Revealed

From the Havenly UX case study (by a former Havenly designer):

- Only 12% of projects met success criteria in Q1 of the year studied
- The biggest failure point was between **client onboarding and design delivery** — the designer didn’t have enough info to get it right the first time
- Clients don’t want to feel burdened during intake, but designers need detailed info to avoid costly revisions

From Modsy’s failure:

- Renderings were outsourced, creating 3-week turnaround times
- If a revision was needed, the client was already a month in with nothing to show
- The lesson: **fast feedback loops matter more than polish**

From general reviews:

- Clients hate when it's obvious the designer didn't look at their preferences
 - The platforms that succeed make the client feel heard at every stage
 - Communication gaps (not design quality) are the #1 complaint
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Prioritized Recommendations for StyleMyShack

Based on this research, here's what I'd suggest focusing on, roughly in priority order:

High Impact, Low Effort

1. **Add visual status to room cards** — "No recommendations yet" / "Ready for review" / "Updated"
2. **Render swatches visually** — the JSONB data should display as colored circles/squares, not raw data
3. **Add an "inspiration" photo type** — let the designer attach reference images alongside room photos
4. **Inline editing** — clicking a recommendation field should let you edit in-place rather than navigating to a separate edit form

High Impact, Medium Effort

5. **Break recommendations into individual items** — instead of a free-text "furniture" field, support multiple furniture items each with a name, photo URL, link, and optional note
6. **Add per-category or per-item feedback** — even just a "client notes" field per category
7. **Designer vs. client view toggle** — a preview mode that shows what the homeowner sees

Aspirational (Good to Know, Build Later)

8. **Approve/decline per item** — the Houzz Selections pattern

9. **Side-by-side before/after** — current room photo next to inspiration/recommendation
 10. **Notification of changes** — “Your designer updated Kitchen recommendations on March 24”
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Key Takeaway

The biggest gap between StyleMyShack’s current UX and “what good looks like” isn’t visual polish or fancy features — it’s **granularity of interaction**. The best tools let clients react to *specific things* (this paint color, that light fixture) rather than *entire rooms*. Every step you take toward more granular recommendations with per-item feedback will move the needle more than any amount of CSS refinement.